

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Army helicopter, airliner crash while in flight over Potomac River, killing all 67 people aboard the two aircraft

Deadliest US air disaster since 2001 comes while staffing at control tower ‘not normal,’ according to officials

Trump calls the tragedy an ‘hour of anguish’ for US, but, without evidence, points his finger at diversity efforts

MIDAIR COLLISION UNDER SCRUTINY



Authorities survey a crash site involving an American Airlines flight and a U.S. Army helicopter in the Potomac River near Washington on Thursday. **KENNY HOLSTON/THE NEW YORK TIMES**

By Lolita C. Baldor, Tara Copp, Brian Melley and Lea Skene
Associated Press

ARLINGTON, Va. — A midair collision between an Army helicopter and an American Airlines flight killed all 67 people aboard the two aircraft, officials said Thursday, as they scrutinized the actions of the military pilot and reported that control tower staff-

ing was “not normal” at the time of the country’s deadliest aviation disaster in almost a quarter-century. At least 28 bodies were pulled from the icy waters of the Potomac River after the helicopter apparently flew into the path of the jet late Wednesday while it was landing at Ronald Reagan National Airport near Washington, officials said. The plane

carried 60 passengers and four crew. Three soldiers were aboard the helicopter. One air traffic controller was responsible for coordinating helicopter traffic and arriving and departing planes when the collision happened, according to a report by the Federal Aviation Administration obtained by The Associated Press. Those duties are often shared by two people, but

the airport typically combines the separate roles at 9:30 p.m. once traffic begins to slow down. The supervisor in the tower directed they be combined earlier. “The position configuration was not normal for the time of day and volume of traffic,” the report said. A person familiar with the matter, however, said the tower

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SKATING COMMUNITY REELS: The jet in the crash was coming from Wichita, Kansas, where the U.S. Figure Skating Championships had ended Sunday. As many as 11 youth skaters and four coaches, including legends of the sport, died in the collision, which has an unimaginable link to past tragedy, writes columnist Philip Hersh. **Chicago Sports**

CEO says he can’t ‘imagine the need’ for CTU strike

By Rebecca Johnson and Ikram Mohamed
Chicago Tribune

Pedro Martinez, the CEO of Chicago Public Schools, said Thursday he “can’t even imagine the need” for the Chicago Teachers Union to go on strike, saying the two sides are on the way to reaching an agreement amid contentious negotiations. “Any work stoppage would only disrupt our children’s learning, and given how close together the sides are, it wouldn’t make any sense to do something so drastic,” Martinez said at the January Board of Education meeting. Martinez spoke Thursday to the newly sworn-in board about the negotiations and ongoing fears at schools of deportation raids as President Donald Trump’s administration cracks down on illegal immigration.

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State flag’s biggest fans not giving up without fight

By Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

Scott Grandchamp was cleaning out the backroom last month at the LaGrange Park Ace Hardware store he owns when he found an untouched Illinois state flag tucked into a safe. He decided to replace a company anniversary flag that he designed with the state flag and has flown it under the American flag every day since. “It’s nice, and I think it’s something that should be flown, and it does represent our state,” Grandchamp said. “I think everybody’s always just raised



Sales associate Tom Koenig raises the Illinois flag outside Ace Hardware in LaGrange Park on Monday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

the American flag, and they don’t raise the state flag. Since I found it and had an extra set of hooks, I said ‘Let’s raise it.’” Maligned by some, the state flag design that’s been used for more than 50 years has its fans. But its future is uncertain, as

the Illinois Flag Commission is a few weeks away from choosing a winner in a contest to design a new flag to represent the Land of Lincoln — although the outcome will be advisory at best.

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County takes harder stance on machine gun cases

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

Cook County State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke has directed prosecutors to seek prison sentences in every felony case involving machine gun-type weapons, according to a new policy circulated to her staff on Thursday. The order is the latest move by the new prosecutor as she seeks to forge a tougher stance on gun crimes per campaign promises and after condemning the city’s gun violence in December when she was ceremonially sworn into office. According to the policy, prosecutors on their own cannot enter into a plea agreement for a probation term or other punishments that do not involve prison time in cases where the defendant used or possessed “any machine gun

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Burke asks for clemency

Imprisoned ex-Ald. Edward Burke has become the latest Chicago Democrat to seek clemency from someone who seems like an unlikely ally: President Donald Trump. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Endeavor laying off staff

Endeavor Health said Thursday it is eliminating inpatient psychiatric services at a hospital in Arlington Heights and laying off a small number of staff elsewhere across the system. **Business**

